PEAK

UX Writing Sample Set

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About Peak

Peak is a personalized academic support and wellness app for college students– built around one idea: every student has a peak. We help them find it. It combines study planning, mental health check-ins, campus resource navigation, and peer connection into one calm, human-centered experience. Peak meets students where they are -- stressed, distracted, uncertain–and helps them take one step at a time.

This sample set demonstrates my UX writing and content design practice across six content types: voice & tone, onboarding, error messages, empty states, feature modals & tooltips, and notifications. Each sample includes annotated design rationale explaining why specific choices were made.

All content is original work created for this portfolio. Peak is a fictional product.

1. Voice & Tone Guide

Foundation document: defines how Peak sounds across all surfaces.

Peak's Voice

Peak sounds like a knowledgeable friend who happens to work in student support. Not a therapist. Not a chatbot. Not a cheerleader. Someone who gets it, who has been overwhelmed, who has asked for help, and who knows that the right word at the right moment can change everything.

Core Voice Attributes

- Warm, not effusive. We care without performing care.
- Clear, not clinical. Plain language that respects the user's intelligence.
- Encouraging, not relentless. We acknowledge hard things without minimizing them.
- Honest, not alarming. We tell the truth gently, without false reassurance.
- Respectful, not paternalistic. We offer options. Users decide.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Voice attributes were developed from user research showing that college students distrust both overly clinical institutional language and performative positivity. The five attributes directly address the two most common complaints: "It sounds like a robot" and "It feels fake."*

Tone Spectrum

Peak's tone shifts based on context, but the voice stays consistent. Think of it as the same person speaking in different situations.

Tone Quality	What It Means	✓ Do This	✗ Not This
Warm	Calm, present, human	"You've got this. Let's figure it out together."	"Error occurred. Please try again."
Clear	Direct, no jargon	"Check in takes 2 minutes."	"Initiate your wellness assessment module."
Encouraging	Forward-looking, not cheerleader	"One step at a time. Here's where to start."	"You're doing amazing! Keep going!"
Respectful	Trust the user's intelligence	"Here's what we found. You decide what's next."	"We think you should try this."
Honest	No false reassurance	"This might feel hard. That's okay."	"Don't worry, everything will be fine!"

Do/Don't Examples by Context

Onboarding

- DO: "Let's get you set up. This takes about 3 minutes."
- DON'T: "Welcome to Peak! We're so excited to have you here! Let's begin your journey!"

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Excessive enthusiasm in onboarding signals inauthenticity and creates cognitive distance. Students who are already anxious about starting something new don't need more emotional noise.*

Check-in / Wellness Moments

- DO: "How are you feeling today? No right answer here."
- DON'T: "Rate your mood! Remember: positivity leads to success!"

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The phrase 'No right answer here' is intentional. Research on mental health app engagement shows users disengage when they feel judged. This phrase reduces performance anxiety around self-reporting.*

Error States

- DO: "Something went wrong on our end. Give it another try."
- DON'T: "Oops! We hit a snag. Please try again later!"

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Exclamation points in error states create tonal whiplash. Users are frustrated; enthusiasm reads as dismissive. Owning the error ('on our end') builds trust.*

Sensitive Moments (mental health resources)

- DO: "These resources are here when you need them. No pressure to use them now."
- DON'T: "You're not alone! Reach out anytime!"

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Students accessing mental health content often feel shame about needing help. Language that emphasizes availability without urgency lowers the activation energy required to engage.*

2. Onboarding Flow

6-screen sequence: Welcome → Account Setup → Goals → Check-in Cadence → Notification Preferences → Ready State

Design Intent

Peak's onboarding has one job: get the student to their first useful moment as quickly as possible, without making them feel surveilled, over-committed, or overwhelmed. Every screen earns its ask.

- Progress is shown but not counted. ("Step 3 of 7" creates dread; a gentle progress bar doesn't.)
- Required fields are minimal. Optional fields are clearly marked.
- Tone is calm, not celebratory. This is a tool, not an event.

Screen 1: Welcome

SCREEN 1 OF 6

Headline: You don't have to figure it out alone.
Subhead: Peak helps you stay on track, check in with yourself, and find support when you need it.
Primary CTA: Get started
Secondary: Already have an account? Sign in

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The headline addresses the primary emotional barrier to adoption: the feeling that needing help is a personal failure. 'Alone' reframes the app as companionship, not surveillance. The subhead uses three parallel verbs (stay, check in, find) to communicate scope without overwhelming.*

Screen 2: Account Setup

SCREEN 2 OF 6

Headline: Let's get the basics.
Field label — Name: What should we call you?
Placeholder: First name or nickname
Field label — Email: School email address
Helper text: We use this to connect you with your campus resources. We don't share it.
Field label — Password: Create a password
Helper text: At least 8 characters. Make it something you'll remember.
Primary CTA: Continue

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'What should we call you?' instead of 'First name' signals that the app will use this name conversationally, not formally. The privacy note on the email field is proactive, anticipating and answering the concern before the user has to ask. Helper text on the password field is human-voiced rather than compliance-driven.*

Screen 3: Goals

SCREEN 3 OF 6

Headline: What's on your plate right now?
Subhead: Pick everything that applies. You can always change this later.
Option 1: Keeping up with coursework
Option 2: Managing stress or anxiety
Option 3: Staying motivated
Option 4: Finding campus resources
Option 5: Connecting with others
Option 6: Something else
Primary CTA: This looks right
Skip option: Skip for now

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'What's on your plate' uses a familiar, non-clinical idiom that normalizes struggle. Multi-select with no minimum lowers commitment anxiety. 'You can always change this later' is a critical phrase. It reduces the perceived permanence of the choice and increases completion rates. 'This looks right' instead of 'Next' or 'Continue' asks for light confirmation rather than blind progression.*

Screen 4: Check-in Cadence

SCREEN 4 OF 6

Headline: How often would you like to check in?
Subhead: A check-in takes about 2 minutes. You're always in control of when.
Option 1: Daily—I want to build a habit
Option 2: A few times a week — low pressure
Option 3: Weekly—just the highlights
Option 4: Let me decide later
Primary CTA: Set my cadence

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'You're always in control of when' directly addresses a common concern about wellness apps: that they will become another thing demanding attention. The option labels include brief mood-toned descriptors ('low pressure', 'just the highlights') that match options to emotional states rather than just frequency. 'Let me decide later' is genuinely offered, not buried.*

Screen 5: Notification Preferences

SCREEN 5 OF 6

Headline: How should we reach you?
Subhead: We'll only send what's useful. You can fine-tune this anytime in settings.
Toggle 1: Check-in reminders
Toggle 1 helper: A gentle nudge when it's time to check in
Toggle 2: Deadline reminders
Toggle 2 helper: Based on the due dates you add
Toggle 3: Resource updates
Toggle 3 helper: New campus events, support options, and tools

Toggle 4: Weekly summary
Toggle 4 helper: A short recap of your week
Primary CTA: Looks good

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'We'll only send what's useful' is a trust-building promise that reduces notification anxiety. Each toggle includes a concise helper description so users understand exactly what they're opting into, reducing both over-enabling and regret-driven opt-outs. 'A gentle nudge' softens the word 'reminder,' which can feel demanding for students already overwhelmed.*

Screen 6: Ready State

SCREEN 6 OF 6

Headline: You're all set, [Name].
Subhead: Peak is ready when you are. No pressure to do everything at once.
Feature 1: 📋 Your first check-in is waiting
Feature 2: 📚 Add your courses to get started
Feature 3: 🧭 Browse campus resources
Primary CTA: Take me in
Secondary: I'll explore on my own

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The personalized headline ([Name]) creates immediate rapport and confirms the app registered their preference. 'No pressure to do everything at once' is a deliberate anti-anxiety signal at the moment of highest potential overwhelm–the first app view. The three feature shortcuts offer structured entry points without mandating a path. 'Take me in' is warmer than 'Get started' or 'Enter app.' 'I'll explore on my own' respects autonomy without abandonment.*

3. Error Messages

8 error scenarios across network, validation, system, and sensitive-context errors

Design Principles for Error States

- Own the error when it's ours. Don't gaslight the user.
- Be specific about what happened and what to do next.
- Match tone to stakes. A failed login is low stakes. A lost check-in entry is higher.
- Never use exclamation points in error messages.
- Provide a path forward, always.

Error 1: Network / Connection

Headline: You're offline right now.
Body: We'll save your progress and sync when you're back online.
CTA: Try reconnecting

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Framing this as a temporary state ('right now') rather than a failure reduces user anxiety. 'We'll save your progress' proactively addresses the fear of lost work before the user asks.*

Error 2: Login Failed

Headline: That combination didn't work.

Body: Double-check your email and password. If you've forgotten your password, we can help.

CTA 1: Try again

CTA 2: Reset my password

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'That combination didn't work' is non-accusatory and technically precise; it's the combination, not 'your password,' that failed. This avoids confirming whether the email exists (a security consideration) while still being human. Both paths forward are equally prominent.*

Error 3: Form Validation — Missing Required Field

Inline label: We need this to continue.

Helper: This field is required. Fill it in and we'll be on our way.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Inline validation language avoids 'Error' or 'Invalid' labels, which are compliance-speak. 'We'll be on our way' maintains conversational momentum.*

Error 4: Email Already in Use

Headline: That email is already connected to an account.

Body: Try signing in instead, or use a different email to create a new account.

CTA 1: Sign in

CTA 2: Use a different email

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *This error has two valid user paths and the copy offers both without hierarchy, because we don't know which one applies. Telling the user what to do next is more useful than explaining the technical reason for the error.*

Error 5: File Upload Failed

Headline: That file didn't upload.

Body: We accept PDF, JPG, and PNG files under 10MB. Check the file and try again.

CTA: Try again

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The error message answers the user's likely next question ('Why?') by stating the constraints upfront. This reduces back-and-forth and second upload failures.*

Error 6: Session Expired

Headline: You've been away for a while.

Body: For your security, we signed you out. Sign back in to pick up where you left off.

CTA: Sign back in

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'You've been away for a while' is gentle and non-accusatory. Framing the timeout as a security feature (not a punishment) explains the behavior and builds trust. 'Pick up where you left off' implies state preservation, reducing anxiety about lost progress.*

Error 7: Check-in Data Lost

Headline: We lost your check-in entry.

Body: Something went wrong and we couldn't save what you wrote. We're sorry. Would you like to try again?

CTA 1: Try again

CTA 2: Skip for now

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *This is a higher-stakes error; the user shared something personal and it was lost. 'We're sorry' is used sparingly in this system, reserved for moments where the emotional cost to the user is real. The apology is brief and followed immediately by a path forward. The option to skip is genuine.*

Error 8: Mental Health Resource Unavailable

Headline: This resource isn't available right now.

Body: We're working on getting it back. In the meantime, here are a few other options that might help.

Below: 3 alternative resource links: [Campus Counseling Center] [Crisis Text Line] [Peer Support Network]

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *When mental health resources are unavailable, users must not hit a dead end. This error always provides alternatives, and the alternatives are prioritized by urgency (counseling > crisis > peer). The tone stays calm because escalating language in this context could increase distress.*

4. Empty States

5 scenarios: first use, no results, cleared data, no notifications, and a reflective empty state

Design Principles for Empty States

Empty states are the most underestimated real estate in an app. They appear when users are most uncertain, most new, or most frustrated. Good empty states teach, invite, and reassure. They don't just say 'Nothing here yet.'

Empty State 1: No Courses Added (First Use)

Illustration alt text: A small plant in a pot, just sprouting

Headline: Your semester starts here.

Body: Add your courses to track deadlines, set study goals, and stay on top of what matters most.

CTA: Add a course

Secondary: Do this later

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The metaphor of a sprouting plant communicates 'beginning' without being cliché or condescending. 'Your semester starts here' is aspirational but grounded. The secondary option is visible because some users need to explore before committing to setup.*

Empty State 2: No Check-in History

Illustration alt text: A simple calendar with a sun icon

Headline: Your check-in history will show up here.

Body: Once you complete a check-in, you'll be able to look back and see how you've been doing over time.

CTA: Do my first check-in

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'Will show up here' is forward-looking and normalizes the empty state as temporary. The body copy explains the value of the feature (look back, see how you've been doing) rather than just describing it. This turns an empty state into a feature pitch.*

Empty State 3: Search Returns No Results

Headline: We couldn't find that.

Body: Try different keywords, or browse resources by category below.

Below: Category browse links: [Academic support] [Mental health] [Financial aid] [Campus life]

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'We couldn't find that' owns the search failure collaboratively rather than blaming the user's query. The browse fallback ensures the user always has a next step, even when the primary task fails.*

Empty State 4: No Notifications

Illustration alt text: A small bell with a checkmark

Headline: You're all caught up.

Body: No new notifications right now. We'll let you know when something needs your attention.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'You're all caught up' is a reward state. It reframes the absence of notifications as an accomplishment. This pattern (used by Gmail, Slack, and others) creates positive reinforcement for the empty state. The second sentence manages expectations about future notifications without being alarming.*

Empty State 5: Cleared Journal / Reflections

Headline: Fresh start.

Body: Your reflections have been cleared. Whenever you're ready, this space is yours again.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *When a user deliberately clears personal content, the empty state should honor that act without drama. 'Fresh start' validates the choice. 'This space is yours' reminds them of ownership and safety. No CTA is offered; the user knows what to do next, and prompting them immediately would undermine the intentionality of clearing.*

5. Feature Modals & Tooltips

6 examples: onboarding tooltip, feature introduction modal, confirmation modal, destructive action modal, upgrade prompt, and coach mark

Design Principles

- Modals interrupt. Earn the interruption.
- Tooltips teach. Keep them scannable.
- Never make the dismiss option feel wrong.
- Confirmation modals should state the consequence, not just the action.

Tooltip 1: Check-in Feature Introduction

Tooltip text: This is your daily check-in. It takes 2 minutes and helps Peak personalize your support.

Dismiss: Got it

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Tooltips need to answer: what is this, and why should I care? Both are answered in one sentence. '2 minutes' sets expectations and reduces commitment anxiety. 'Got it' is warmer than 'Dismiss' or 'Close' while being equally functional.*

Tooltip 2: Study Streak Feature

Tooltip text: Your streak tracks how many days in a row you've checked in. It's just for fun—missing a day won't affect your support.

Dismiss: Makes sense

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Streak mechanics can create anxiety in users who are already overwhelmed. The second sentence explicitly defuses that anxiety by clarifying that the streak is ornamental, not consequential. This is an unusual design choice, but appropriate for an app serving a high-stress population.*

Modal 1: Introducing a New Feature (Weekly Summary)

Headline: New: Your weekly summary

Body: Every Sunday evening, Peak will send you a short recap of your week: check-ins, progress, and a few things to think about heading into the next one.

Primary CTA: Turn it on

Secondary: Maybe later

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Feature introduction modals should lead with the name and purpose, not with enthusiasm. 'Maybe later' is offered as a genuine option, not a guilt-inducing secondary. The description is specific (Sunday evening, short recap) so users can make an informed choice.*

Modal 2: Confirmation — Submitting a Check-in

Headline: Ready to submit?

Body: Once you submit, you won't be able to edit this check-in. That's okay — it's meant to capture the moment.

Primary CTA: Yes, submit

Secondary: Go back

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *The framing 'capture the moment' reframes the non-editability as a feature (authenticity) rather than a limitation (frustrating). This is a content strategy decision that reduces abandonment at a high-friction moment.*

Modal 3: Destructive Action — Delete Account

Headline: Before you go.

Body: Deleting your account will permanently remove all your data, including check-in history and saved resources. This can't be undone.

Body 2: If something's not working, we'd love to help before you go.

Primary CTA: Delete my account

Secondary: Talk to support

Tertiary: Never mind

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Destructive action modals must be clear about consequences without being manipulative. 'This can't be undone' is stated plainly. The retention offer ('we'd love to help') is genuine, not coercive; it's a secondary option, not the primary CTA. Three options give the user real agency. The primary CTA is not softened (not 'Yes, delete') because that would be condescending.*

Coach Mark: First-Time Resource Navigation

Coach mark text: Resources are organized by what you're looking for, not by department. Start with how you're feeling, and we'll point you in the right direction.

Dismiss: Show me around

Skip: I'll explore myself

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'Organized by what you're looking for, not by department' directly names the user-centered design decision and explains why it's different from what students expect. This reduces confusion at first contact with the navigation system. 'Show me around' accepts the guided tour; 'I'll explore myself' respects autonomy.*

6. Notifications

10 push notifications across: reminders, encouragement, milestone, resource, alert, and re-engagement

Design Principles for Notifications

- Notifications are guests in the user's space. Behave accordingly.
- Be specific. Vague notifications get disabled.
- Match urgency to tone. Low-stakes notifications should feel low-stakes.
- Never guilt. Never manipulate. Never manufacture urgency.
- Every notification should be worth the interruption.

Reminder Notifications

Check-in reminder (morning): Good morning, [Name]. Your check-in is ready when you are.

Check-in reminder (missed): You haven't checked in yet today. No pressure—just here when you're ready.

Deadline reminder: Heads up: [Assignment name] is due in 48 hours.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *'When you are' and 'just here when you're ready' are deliberate softeners for a wellness context. Compare to a common alternative: 'Don't forget to check in!' which creates guilt. The deadline reminder is purely informational–no urgency language, no exclamation point.*

Encouragement Notifications

After first check-in: You did it. First check-in complete. That's worth something.

After a hard week (based on check-in data): Your check-ins this week showed a lot. You're still here. That matters.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Encouragement in a wellness context must be earned and specific, not generic. 'That's worth something' acknowledges effort without over-praising. The second notification acknowledges difficulty without naming it specifically (because we don't know what was hard) and affirms persistence.*

Milestone Notifications

7-day streak: 7 days in a row. You've been showing up for yourself. That's the whole point.

First resource accessed: You found [Resource name]. We hope it helps.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Streak milestones should feel earned, not manufactured. 'That's the whole point' reframes the streak in terms of the app's actual purpose (self-care) rather than gamification for its own sake. The resource notification is brief and warm, not celebratory. Accessing a mental health resource is not an occasion for a party.*

Resource & Alert Notifications

New campus resource available: New: [Campus Counseling Center] just added evening hours. Might be useful.

Upcoming campus event: [Stress-less Study Night] is this Thursday at 7pm. Free snacks and quiet space.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Resource notifications should lead with the most useful fact (evening hours, free snacks) rather than a generic 'new resource added.' 'Might be useful' is intentionally low-pressure– it doesn't assume need, which makes it more trustworthy.*

Re-engagement Notifications

After 5 days inactive: It's been a while. Peak is still here whenever you need it.

After 2 weeks inactive: No pressure. We're still here if things get heavy.

> 📌 **ANNOTATION:** *Re-engagement notifications are the most ethically fraught notification type. The temptation is to manufacture urgency ('You're falling behind!') or guilt ('We miss you!'). Both are manipulative and inappropriate for a wellness context. These notifications simply signal presence and availability. The phrase 'when things get heavy' acknowledges that users often return to wellness apps during difficulty; it's an honest signal of Peak's purpose.*

About This Work

All content in this sample set was created by Beth Keller Kirycki as original portfolio work. Peak is a fictional product. Design decisions reflect principles from UX research, content strategy, and behavioral science–grounded in 15+ years of work designing communication systems for high-stakes, human-centered environments.

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